supporting the United Front against the Taliban and trying to portray itself as politically neutral and non-interventionist at the same time. This was markedly different from India's dealing with the rise of the Mujahideen in 1992. What stayed the same in 1996 (with the situation in 1992) was the Taliban's desire, like the Mujahideen, to engage with India. The partisans dominated the policy scene throughout the late 1990s. Though the temporary fall of Mazar-e-Sharif in 1997 put pressure on the partisans to engage with the Taliban and view the Afghan landscape realistically, this did not happen. The next two chapters explain why.